



'CURIOSITY OPENS NEW DOORS'

Vineet Nayar

► **THROUGH THE SAMPARK** Foundation, which he had quietly built during his years at HCL Technologies, Nayar found himself engaging directly with children, teachers, and communities at scale. "There is no abstraction. Just real impact. It felt like being human again."

Unlike many leaders who discover their next phase only after leaving corporate life, Nayar says his transition was deeply intentional. He had decided early on that he would step away from corporate leadership at 50 and spend his next chapter focused on social

impact through Sampark Foundation.

"When you are leading a large, listed company that is doing well, there is a certain momentum, even a pull, that is hard to walk away from," he says. "But once the why is clear, the how becomes an exciting journey of discovery."

Nayar says the real risk is an entitlement mindset, which often makes one believe that because of their work as a CEO, the world would continue seeking their advice, even after they step aside. "The world has moved on," he says.

Instead, he says, former leaders add the most value through mentoring, governance, and social impact, provided they stop trying to operate like executives. Leading change in education, he realised, was profoundly different from driving change inside corporations.

"At HCL, I learnt how to motivate employees through a shared philosophy," he says. "At Sampark, I learned how to inspire people through ideas

and human impact."

Unlike business, where change can be driven through structure and incentives, in education, especially within government systems, one has to inspire people. Today, Sampark's work reaches millions of children across India, something Nayar says feels larger than anything he imagined achieving in corporate life. "I moved from working with employees to working with humans at their most foundational level — children and teachers," he says. "You see very clearly whether what you do is making a difference." What followed was a renewed sense of curiosity through writing, reflection, and deeper engagement with ideas beyond business.

"Curiosity opens new doors," Nayar says. "It allows you to keep learning, keep exploring, and keep evolving. And that is what keeps you truly alive in any phase of life."